More than other officials, Rusk had hoped for more Indian support for Vietnam policy because he saw it as serving an Indian interest —"thwart[ing] China's ambitions"—as well. He had been frustrated that Indian officials would not make any statements of support or shared interests with the US, believing the reluctance was because of India's relationship with the Soviet Union.[102] Now, he saw outright opposition. Furious, he called Gandhi's shift an "outrageous departure from non-alignment." Rusk doubted not just India's ability but its willingness to stand against China, noting, "Do you really think that there is one chance in a thousand that India would take any action to be a counter-weight to Communist China in Asia unless India itself were attacked?"[103]

The US secretary of state was not entirely wrong; there was a shared interest. Indian officials did worry about "great Chinese pressure and influence in Vietnam" and the consequences of a hasty American withdrawal, albeit internally. Even Indian ambassador to Moscow Triloki Nath (T. N.) Kaul, not considered a supporter of US policy, outlined the Indian concern, noting to a Soviet editor, "Even if the Americans leave, will the Chinese leave?"[104]

But there were two key differences on how to attain the shared objective. First, Delhi believed that Washington should make Moscow part of its Vietnam solution and focus on diplomacy rather than force. Foreign Minister Mahomedali Currim (M. C.) Chagla told Rusk "that so far as China was concerned there was a coincidence of interests of the Soviet Union, United States and India." When Rusk asked why then India did not support the US position in Vietnam, Chagla noted that the war was counterproductive. It "merely helped China and gave her a footing in North Vietnam which, left to themselves, the North Vietnamese would, in the context of their historical relations with the Chinese, not permit."[105] Second, Indian officials thought the US had exaggerated concerns about a united Vietnam, which India thought would likely help counterbalance China.[106]

The divergence on Vietnam remained apparent throughout fall 1966. In October, after Gandhi, Nasser, and Tito met in Delhi, their communiqué appealed for an unconditional cessation of bombing. They called for the withdrawal of all foreign forces from Vietnam, while mentioning the necessity of Viet Cong participation in any negotiations.[107]